Centralized Student Choice and Assignment Systems in China's Mandatory Education

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Abstract

The adoption of Centralized Student Choice and Assignment Systems (CCAS) has been on the rise worldwide. From 2003 to 2022, major Chinese cities gradually established CCAS in primary and secondary school admissions. I assemble the first dataset that documents the presence and attributes of CCAS for all 134 cities whose populations exceeded one million each. I provide descriptive evidence on the adoption patterns and heterogeneity in implementation details. Then I estimate a diffusion model to investigate the determinants of CCAS adoption. Results suggest that city population and male average education correlate with earlier adoption, with caveats of small sample size and the difficulty in identifying peer effects. The wide coverage and heterogeneity of CCAS warrant more research on their optimal local forms and welfare implications.

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I Introduction

A Centralized Student Choice and Assignment System is characterized by educational institutions with externally determined enrollments, applicants who submit preference lists to a centralized authority, and a mechanism that issues each student a single offer based on specific criteria and allocation rules. Neilson (2024) reviews 149 countries, and 60 percent of these countries employ some form of coordinated assignment mechanism at the primary, secondary, or tertiary education level. The global expansion of Centralized Student Choice and Assignment Systems (CCAS) underscores the importance of understanding how centralized systems perform across heterogeneous socioeconomic and institutional environments.

A growing literature demonstrates that although CCAS can reduce matching frictions and improve equity and efficiency, their realized impacts depend sensitively on policy design details–such as the assignment mechanisms (Ergin and Sönmez, 2006; Agarwal and Somaini, 2018), priority rules (Calsamiglia, Fu and Güell, 2020), preference list lengths (Haeringer and Klijn, 2009), the information provided to families and its influence on beliefs (Kapor, Neilson and Zimmerman, 2020; Arteaga et al., 2022), and the regulation of off-platform options (Akbarpour et al., 2022; Kapor, Karnani and Neilson, 2024). Documenting how CCAS are implemented in practice is therefore essential for identifying the institutional and political conditions under which centralized systems are feasible and welfare-enhancing, informing jurisdictions seeking to adopt or improve their school-choice platforms.

China is a particularly relevant setting for studying CCAS. With 291 million students and 19 million full-time teachers, the Chinese education system is large, heterogeneous, and administratively capable (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2024). System-wide reforms can diffuse beyond local boundaries, and observed policy patterns may inform other emerging education markets. However, while extensive literature examines the college admissions system (Gaokao) (Chen and Kesten, 2017, 2019), remarkably little is known about how primary and secondary schools[1] admit students and the prevalence of city-level CCAS, despite the fact that these school levels structure nearly all future educational opportunities.

The Gaokao—a province-administered nationwide entrance examination—has long determined priority in tertiary admissions. China adopted a centralized tertiary assignment system in 1952 to resolve misallocation and inequity under decentralized admissions, building on coordinated reforms among 73 universities in 1950 (Yang, 2007; Chen and Kesten, 2017). Subsequent reforms, including the shift from sequential to parallel mechanisms, reduced manipulation and improved perceived fairness (Chen and Kesten, 2019). The Gaokao system has thus been the primary CCAS reference point in China, and a substantial literature examines its sociological and economic implications (Liu, 2013; Gierczyk and Diao, 2021; Jia and Li, 2021; Roland and Yang, 2017).

In contrast, the admission systems governing primary and secondary education remain underdocumented. Existing surveys describe governance structures and curriculum, but offer minimal detail on school–student matching

[1] In China, primary school lasts six years, middle school three years, and high school three years. Primary and middle school education are compulsory. The local Bureau of Education often addresses them using the same policy document. Therefore, this paper jointly discusses primary and middle school education. Secondary education includes middle and high school, which are also referred to as junior and senior secondary school. High schools follow a separate policy document. Basic education refers to twelve years of primary, middle, and high school education.

mechanisms (Guo, Huang and Zhang, 2019; OECD, 2016; Zhou, 2021). No study, to my knowledge, systematically documents the adoption of CCAS in primary and secondary school or the variation in their design. This paper fills that gap.

I assemble a cross-sectional admission policy dataset for all 134 cities with populations above one million each in 2020, by aggregating information from municipal bureaus of education, local news, and blogs. As of 2022, all 134 cities had implemented CCAS for high school admissions, while 114 had done so for mandatory education (primary and middle school). I compile variations in assignment mechanisms[2], list lengths, priority rules, and public–private coordination.

I find that in the high school CCAS examined, most encompass both public and private schools, with a considerable variation in list lengths across cities. Among the 73 cities with documented mechanisms, nearly 60 percent primarily employ the Chinese Parallel mechanism, despite the proven stability and strategy-proofness of the Deferred Acceptance mechanism (Gale and Shapley, 1962; Roth, 1982; Abdulkadiroğlu and Sönmez, 2003; Chen and Sönmez, 2006; Ergin and Sönmez, 2006). Approximately 13 percent use Deferred Acceptance, another 13 percent use the Boston mechanism. About 8 percent combine Serial Dictatorship and Boston. The remaining 7 percent allow students to adjust their preferences before a specified deadline or in real-time as information is updated. While minor variations exist in break-tie rules and priority groups across cities, they generally follow stable and predictable patterns on a larger scale.

High school CCAS and mandatory education CCAS domains differ markedly in timing and institutional drivers. High school CCAS expanded gradually from 2003 to 2022, with an acceleration between 2010 and 2016. However, mandatory education CCAS expanded rapidly after 2019, as a result of a national mandate requiring unified admissions for public and private schools. High school CCAS therefore reflects a more bottom-up pattern of experimentation and diffusion; mandatory-education (primary and middle school) CCAS reflects a centrally sponsored, top-down rollout.

Understanding what drives CCAS adoption also helps researchers and policymakers assess a city's readiness to implement a centralized assignment system. A growing literature shows that centralized school–student matching systems that reduce scope for outside maneuvers tend to improve equity and raise welfare. Akbarpour et al. (2022) demonstrate that heterogeneity in students' outside options generates systematic inequities under manipulable mechanisms—students with better outside options behave more strategically and obtain better assignments—while strategy-proof mechanisms reduce this advantage. Kapor, Karnani and Neilson (2024) document that expanding a centralized higher-education platform in Chile raised on-time graduation rates and made welfare, enrollment, and graduation less sensitive to off-platform frictions, with larger gains for students from lower-socioeconomic backgrounds. Together, these studies show that reducing outside-option dependence and expanding centralized choice and assignment platforms are central to education equity, making it important to understand the practical and political factors that shape CCAS adoption in Chinese cities.

[2]Major assignment mechanisms include Deferred Acceptance, Boston, Serial Dictatorship, Chinese Parallel. For a survey of mechanisms, refer to Bonkoungou and Nesterov (2021) and Neilson (2024).

Therefore, I study the diffusion of high school CCAS using a discrete-time hazard model following DellaVigna and Kim (2025) and Li, Zhu and Chen (2024). My specification allows me to distinguish two broad forces that shape CCAS emergence: (1) whether cities learn from and imitate prior adopters (diffusion through exposure), and (2) whether structural and baseline characteristics make reform more likely in some cities than others.

My findings indicate little statistical support for diffusion through exposure. Instead, adoption is more consistently associated with baseline characteristics such as city population size and average male educational attainment. Results suggest that CCAS adoption was driven less by learning through geographic proximity or peer effects and more by local administrative capacity or preferences, provincial directives, or school competition in the local education market.

However, these patterns should be interpreted critically. My sample size is small, and distinguishing true learning effects from spatially correlated institutional environments is intrinsically difficult (Manski, 1993). Shared provincial guidelines, and unobserved administrative capacity can generate spatial clustering even in the absence of informational diffusion. The hazard estimates should therefore be viewed as preliminary descriptive evidence on correlates of adoption, rather than causal estimates of peer influence.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section II details the data structure and data collection methods for the CCAS cross-section. Sections III and IV provide descriptive statistics and a narrative for the gradual expansion of CCAS in high school and mandatory education in 21st-century China. Sections V and VI summarize the attributes of current CCAS in 2022. Section VII proposes and estimate a hazard model of diffusion for CCAS adoption. Section VIII concludes. Details of the timing of CCAS adoption and procedures of school enrollment in China are included in the appendix.[3]

II Data

A China CCAS Dataset

I construct a cross-sectional dataset describing the admissions policies of primary and secondary education systems in 134 major Chinese cities in 2022.[4] To maximize the population coverage of this study, cities are included if their 2020 population exceeded one million.[5] For each city, I record whether a centralized student assignment system operates in mandatory and high school education and collect detailed attributes of any existing CCAS, including the participating institutions (public, private, or both), the length of students' preference lists, the application website, the year the current CCAS was implemented, priority rules, and the underlying assignment mechanism (e.g., Deferred Acceptance, Chinese Parallel, Serial Dictatorship, Boston).

CCAS are coded as present if the city or its districts operate a centralized system that assigns each student

[3] This working paper, including the appendix, is available on SSRN.

[4] In the few cases where 2022 documents are unavailable, I rely on 2021 or 2023 documents.

[5] Population data come from citypopulation.de, based on the 2020 census. I exclude the Wanzhou District of Chongqing and Changsha Xian of Changsha because they are sub-city districts; CCAS are defined at the municipal level, whose Chinese names end with "city" ("shi").

to a single school seat and that governs admission into either public schools alone or both public and private schools. These distinctions are used in subsequent analysis. “Participating institutions” identifies whether the centralized system covers public schools, private schools, or both. “List lengths” capture the number of schools a student may rank on the centralized platform, though their interpretation varies with the mechanism in place. I document priority groups and mechanisms as well. “Application website” is the online platform through which parents submit student information and preference lists; while typically a government domain, some entries in the dataset are intermediate webpages or WeChat-based platforms when the primary website cannot be located, or when multiple application sites are available, or when the application method deviates from a traditional website to a WeChat official account or app.

Information on these attributes is drawn primarily from publicly available policy documents issued by municipal Bureaus of Education.[6] When official documents are missing or lack key details, I supplement them with information from blogs and news sources targeted at local parents. These sources are credible—usually produced by schools or education consultants—and display high redundancy in structure and phrasing, consistent with heavy reuse of official material.

For mandatory education, identifying the existence of a centralized system requires determining whether public and private school applications are handled jointly or separately. Because mandatory systems guarantee each eligible child exactly one seat and prohibit assignment to multiple public schools, this joint/separate distinction is sufficient for classification. To retrieve information efficiently, my Baidu[7] queries focus on questions about how public and private school applications relate to each other, rather than mirroring the full vocabulary describing CCAS attributes.

For high school admissions, the public–private distinction is less informative. Cities group high schools into a small number of batches, and students apply sequentially across these batches; usually admission in an earlier batch renders a student ineligible for later ones. Private and public schools are usually integrated into different batches of the same admission system. Sometimes public and private schools belong to the same batch (e.g., Tangshan). The combination of single assignment within batches and sequential batch structure ensures a unique assignment and therefore constitutes a centralized choice and assignment system.

A key data element is the implementation year of each CCAS. For high schools, I define the implementation year as the date when a city transitioned from decentralized to centralized assignment. Because historical policy documents are scarce, I identify switch years using combinations of keywords such as “centralized platform,” “initiated,” “first time,” and “started,” which frequently return local news reports documenting the launch of the centralized online application platform. When no such reports exist, I manually search across the years 2000–2022 until identifying the first year in which a centralized platform is described and the prior year lacks such evidence. This procedure yields implementation years for 129 of 134 cities.

However, this approach is limited by several implicit assumptions. First, I assume that the establishment of

[6]For example, “Guiding Opinions on [City] mandatory/High School Education Enrollment in 2022.”
[7]Major search engine in China, similar in function to Google and Bing.

CCAS is synonymous with the adoption of an online centralized platform, which parents use to provide their children's profiles for verification, submit preference lists, and receive assignments. This substitution is unavoidable because only information regarding the latter is present, and that CCAS is a new concept. It is credible because for the cities that had enough information in the year of the switch, this assumption always held. Second, since the single assignment criterion was not explicitly verified during the search process, I also assume that the key features of CCAS have remained stable over time since the initial switch, thus justifying a system being recognized as CCAS at its inception because it functions as such presently. This assumption could not be checked because the granularity of policies details diminishes as I delve further into the past. Third, there is an overarching assumption that policies are executed as articulated in official documents. I am conducting interviews with local officials and school teachers to verify this. So far, evidence from Changsha supports this assumption.

For compulsory education, implementation years are often stated explicitly in official documents or news sources (e.g., "This year is the first year our city enforces a fully centralized admission scheme"), allowing a more precise definition: the year when the current CCAS was established, without requiring that earlier systems were identical to the present one.

B City Characteristics Dataset

To estimate the diffusion model, I construct a panel dataset of socioeconomic and geographic characteristics for the same 134 cities over 2003–2022, using the China City Statistical Yearbook. I merge these data with the CCAS cross-section. The resulting dataset includes: city, province, and region names; city longitude and latitude; CCAS establishment year; log year-end registered population; Gross Regional Product (GRP) per capita; and baseline (2002) characteristics including average years of education for females and males, the share of employment in agriculture and industry, and logged agricultural and industrial output per capita. These variables capture both long-run socioeconomic fundamentals and spatial relationships that are central to the CCAS diffusion analysis.

III The Adoption of CCAS over Time: High School

Table A1 provides a summary of the names of the sampled cities, their population in 2020, and the years in which they established a CCAS in high school and compulsory education admissions. The adoption of high school CCAS exhibited a gradual trend from 2003 to 2022. Using the method elaborated in Section II, I identified establishment dates for 129 out of 134 cities.[8] The five cities with missing data all have a below-median population. Taizhou, Cixi and Jiangyin are in the second quartile of the population distribution, while Changshu and Zhangjiagang are in the first quartile. Jiangyin, Changshu and Zhangjiagang are in Jiangsu Province, and Taizhou, Cixi are in Zhejiang Province. Both of these provinces have large populations and each has 17 and 11 cities whose population exceeded 1 million in 2020, respectively. Consequently, it is reasonably safe to assume that the omission of these

[8]However, as will be made clear in Section V, all 134 cities have a city-level CCAS for their high schools as of 2022.

cities does not introduce structural bias, as they can be roughly represented by neighboring cities sharing the same provincial government or similar geographical and cultural traits.

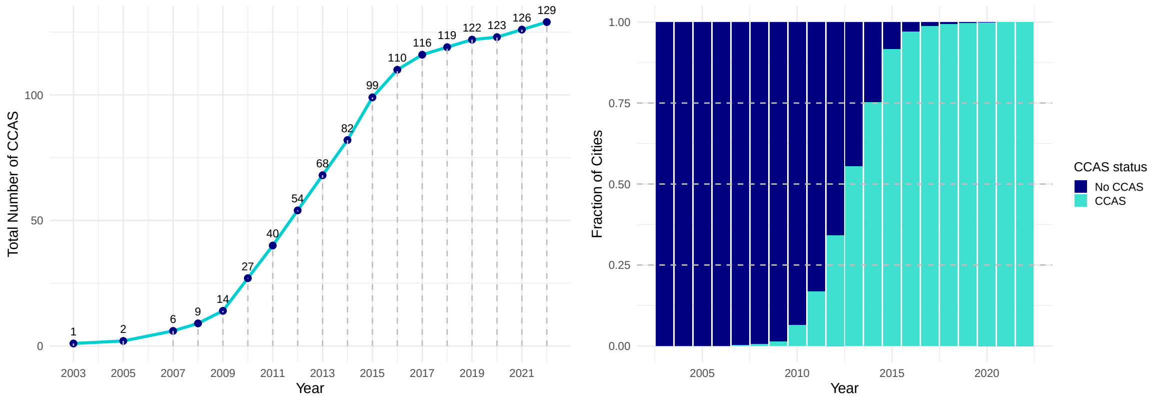
Figure 1 illustrates the cumulative adoption of high school CCAS over time. Together with Figure 2, we see that 2010-2016 witnessed a significant upsurge in CCAS adoption among the largest cities in China. This period contrasts with the relatively slow progress observed from 2003 to 2009 and from 2017 to 2022. Guangdong's provincial capital, Shenzhen, established the first high school CCAS in China in 2003. Other cities in Guangdong and Fujian provinces swiftly followed suit, suggesting the possibility of a policy spillover to nearby areas. Among the cities that adopted CCAS before 2010, Beijing, Shanghai, Changsha, and Chengdu were not geographically coterminous to Shenzhen but were among the most developed cities in China. Consequently, they were presumably well-equipped to be the next candidates for a transition to CCAS. New adoptions peaked in 2015. After 2018, there were sporadic adoptions of CCAS. As of 2023, not only all of these 129 cities, but also the five cities whose CCAS establishment dates are unavailable, have have implemented a city-level high school CCAS.

This partial explanation addresses the "how" but leaves the "why" of the surge in CCAS adoption from 2010 to 2016 unanswered. Further research examining other policies, as well as socioeconomic, technological, and institutional shifts over the past two decades, is required to provide a comprehensive explanation for the rise in high school CCAS adoption. The driving force behind the wave of CCAS adoption from 2010 to 2016 remains an open question. Given that CCAS adoption is largely associated with the establishment of an online platform where parents can submit children's information and preferences and receive notifications of the final school assignment results, one might surmise that technological feasibility played a significant role. China achieved full connectivity to the Internet in 1994, and efforts to use the Internet as a means of bridging the government and the general public have been ongoing since 1999 (Liu and Pan, 2017). More research is needed to evaluate the existence of technological barriers that could have hindered the establishment of CCAS. Many news reports announcing the transition to an online school choice platform emphasized the goal of simplifying the school choice process for parents. The government has labeled the adoption of a centralized school application platform to be a part of the government's systematic effort guided by the ideology to "make things more convenient for the people" ("bian min"). While there may have been pressure from parents to improve the application process, no documentation supporting this notion has been found. This partially answers why CCAS have been established but not why there was a surge in 2010-2016. Further research on other policies and socioeconomic, technological, and institutional shifts in the past two decades is needed to provide a coherent explanation for the pattern of the rise of high school CCAS adoption.

Figure 1: The Accumulation of High School CCAS over Time

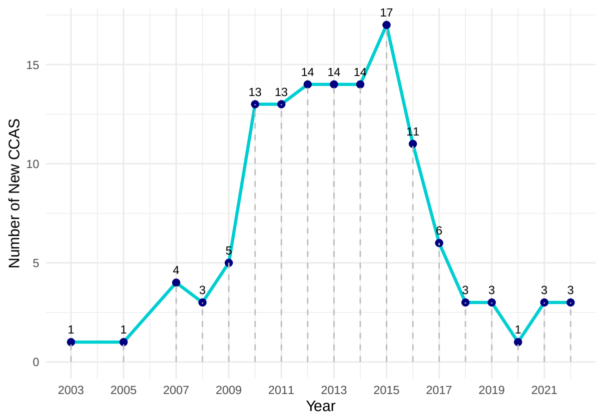
(a) Number of Cities Adopting CCAS by Year

(b) Fraction of Cities Adopting CCAS by Year



Notes: This figure describes the over time adoption of high school city-level CCAS among the 129 cities. Panel (a) presents the cumulative number of CCAS from 2003 to 2022. Panel (b) shows the fraction of cities with a CCAS versus those without a CCAS in each given year.

Figure 2: The Annual Count of New High School CCAS

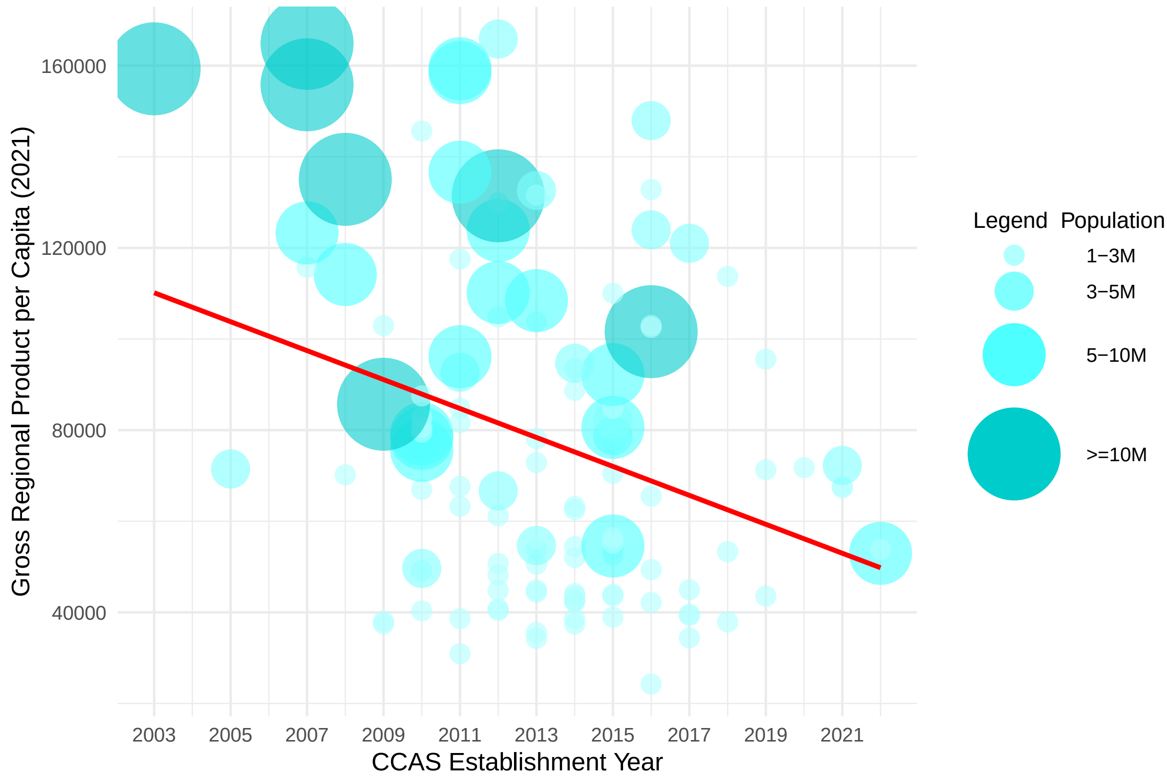


Notes: This figure displays the annual count of newly adopted high school city-level CCAS among the 129 cities.

Figure 3 plots 129 cities' per capita Gross Regional Product (GRP) in 2021 against their high school CCAS establishment years. The GRP data are from the National Bureau of Statistics' China City Statistical Yearbook.[9] The size of each bubble is proportional to the city's population in 2020, which is annotated on the bubbles. The Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression line without controls is downward sloping, suggesting a potential negative relationship between GRP and CCAS establishment year. In other words, regions with higher levels of development may have adopted CCAS earlier. However, for a more robust exploration of valid predictors of CCAS adoption, a larger sample size and data on additional city characteristics beyond what the City Statistical Yearbook offers are necessary. Future research may address this issue.

[9] Please see here.

Figure 3: CCAS Establishment Year (High School)



Notes: This figure plots 129 cities' per capita Gross Regional Product (GRP) in 2021 against their high school CCAS establishment years. The size of each bubble is proportional to the city's population in 2020, which is annotated on the bubbles. The red Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression line without controls is downward sloping, suggesting regions with higher levels of development may have adopted CCAS earlier.

IV The Adoption of CCAS over Time: Primary and Middle School

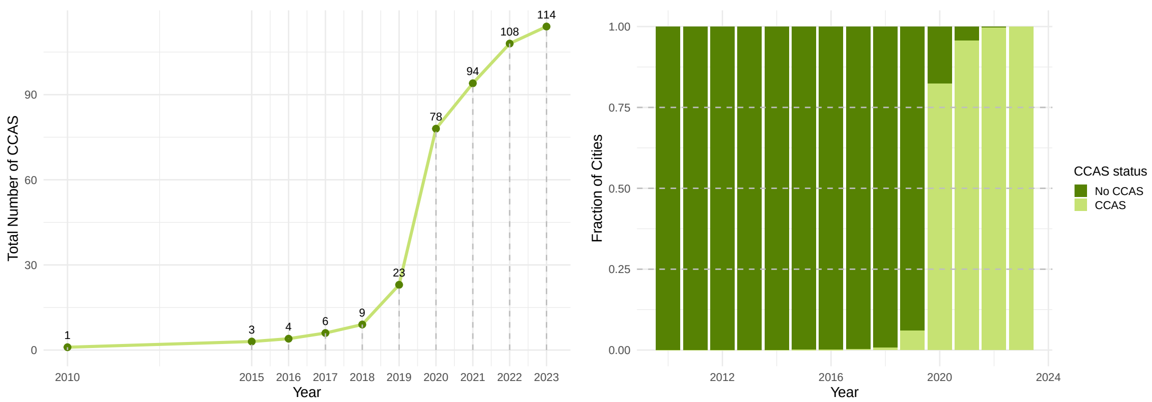
The adoption of CCAS for primary and middle schools took a significantly different path compared to that for high schools. In 2018, China's Ministry of Education first suggested synchronized admission of private and public schools nation-wide in its annual guideline notice for basic education enrollment.[10] In 2019, the regulation was restated with an additional emphasis on its main objective of eliminating the any selection of students by schools within mandatory education.[11] The unification of public and private school admissions aimed to enhance the equitable distribution of educational resources and reduce the parents' stress when navigating the system. Based on municipal policy documents, all sampled cities had implemented the synchronization policy by 2022.

[10]Please see here.
[11]Please see here.

Figure 4: The Accumulation of Primary and Middle School CCAS over Time

(a) Number of Cities Adopting CCAS by Year

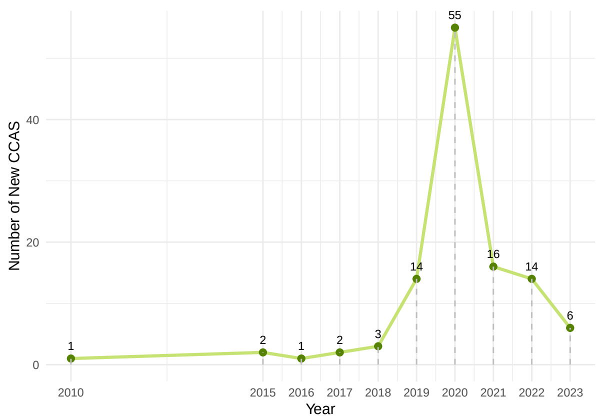
(b) Fraction of Cities Adopting CCAS by Year



Notes: This figure describes the over time adoption of primary and middle school city-level CCAS among 114 cities. Panel (a) presents the cumulative number of CCAS from 2010 to 2023. Panel (b) shows the fraction of cities with a CCAS verses those without a CCAS in each given year.

Using the search method outlined in Section II, I was able to determine the city-level CCAS establishment year for 114 out of 134 cities. Figure 4 provides an overview of the adoption of city-level CCAS for primary and middle schools across these 114 cities over time. Panel (a) presents the cumulative number of CCAS from 2010 to 2023. Panel (b) illustrates the fraction of cities with a CCAS versus those without one in each year. The adoption of CCAS for mandatory education is notably concentrated in 2020, following the MoE's emphasis on its implementation in 2019. Overall, CCAS adoption at the mandatory education level tends to occur later than at the high school level, indicating a general pattern of centralization gradually "trickling down" different tiers of education, from tertiary to secondary to primary. Figure 5 plots the yearly adoption of CCAS. Nearly half of the sampled cities transitioned to CCAS in 2020, while a significant number did in 2019, 2021, and 2022. However, beyond this time frame, there were few instances of CCAS adoptions.

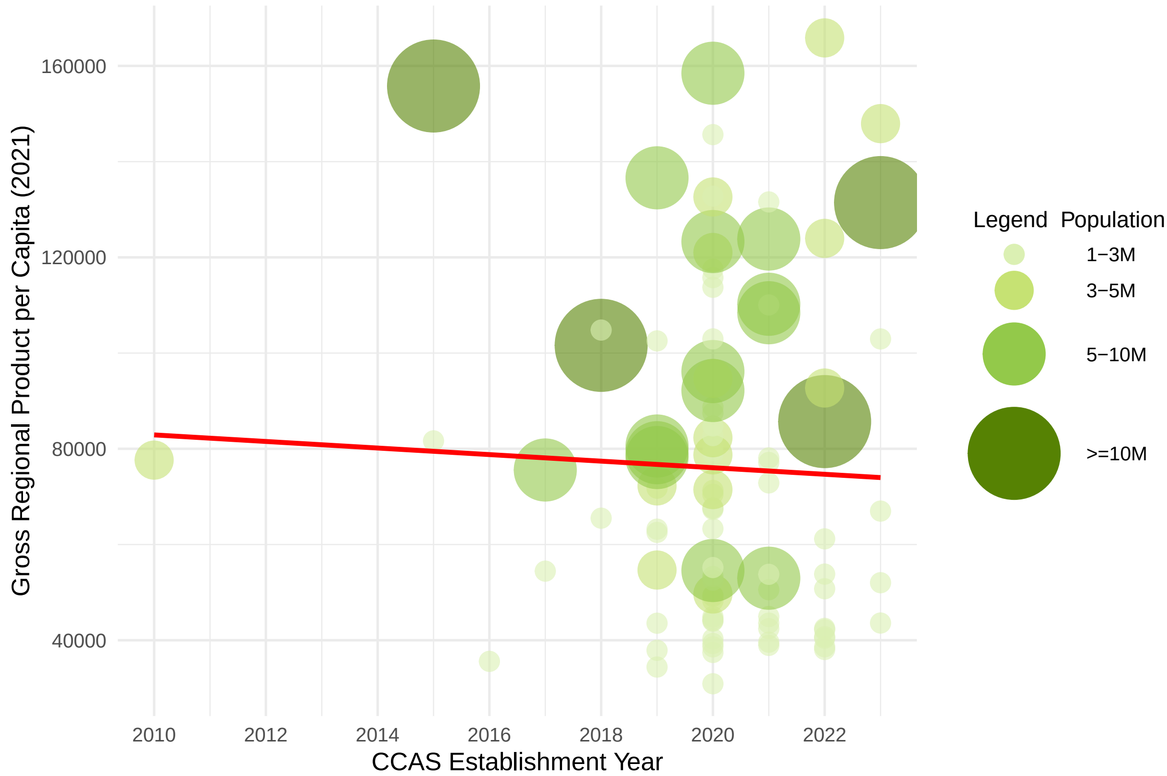
Figure 5: The Annual Count of New Primary and Middle School CCAS



Notes: This figure displays the annual count of newly adopted primary and middle school city-level CCAS among the 114 cities.

Figure 6 explores the potential correlation between the establishment year of mandatory education CCAS and city characteristics such as GRP per capita and population size. There is not a clear relationship between cities adopting CCAS earlier and having a higher GRP per capita or a larger population. This suggests that other factors may be influencing the varied adoption of CCAS despite the presence of a shared national policy. Further research is necessary to uncover the underlying reasons for this uneven adoption pattern.

Figure 6: CCAS Establishment Year (Primary and Middle School)



Notes: This figure plots 114 cities' per capita Gross Regional Product (GRP) in 2021 against their compulsory education CCAS establishment years. The size of each bubble is proportional to the city's population in 2020, which is annotated on the bubbles. The red Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression line without controls is flat, suggesting no correlation between regional development level and CCAS adoption time.

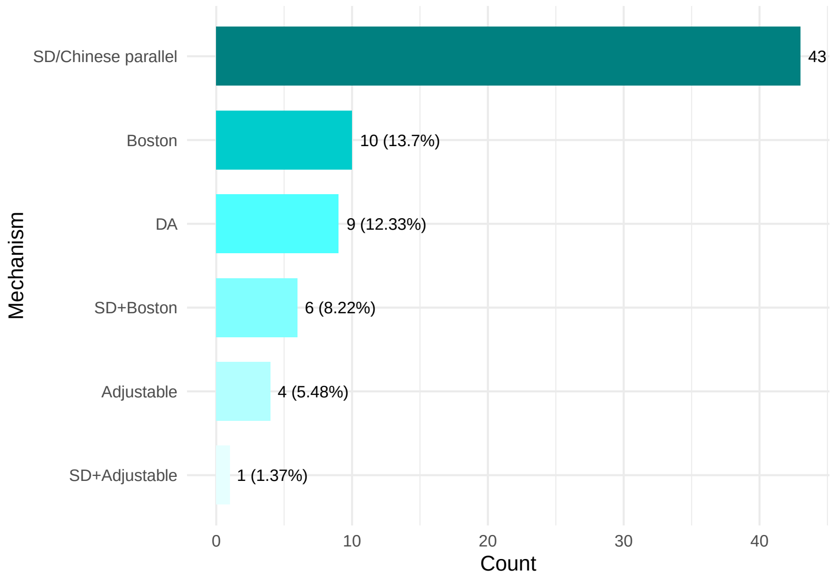
V Current CCAS: High School

After discussing the historical adoption trend of CCAS for high schools and mandatory education, I will now provide an overview of the characteristics of the existing CCAS in the cross-sectional dataset I have compiled for 134 cities.

A Participating Institutions

While data regarding CCAS establishment dates are missing for 5 cities, it is evident that by 2022, all 134 cities have implemented a city-level CCAS for their high schools. Since high schools are also subject to the policy that "private and public schools admit together," the majority of existing CCAS cover both private and public schools. There are a few exceptions, such as Guilin and Rizhao, where the CCAS operates at the city-public level, as private

Figure 7: The Distribution of Mechanisms among High School CCAS



Notes: This bar chart plots the distribution of mechanisms found among 73 cities' high school CCAS. The name of the mechanism, the absolute number of occurrences and the percentage are annotated on the graph.

school admission has not yet been integrated into the same regulatory system. In these cases, students or parents must physically visit their preferred private school to apply, indicating a decentralized application process.

B List Length

List lengths for CCAS applications vary significantly among cities, with almost no two cities sharing the same list length. The number of batches varies from 2 to 15, and there is usually a maximum list length set for each batch. While some batches require students to indicate their preferences, others may not require this.

C Mechanisms

Figure 7 provides an overview of the distribution of different mechanisms among the 73 cities whose mechanisms I could infer.[12] Among the 73 cities, 43 predominantly employ the Chinese Parallel mechanism. Six cities explicitly use a combination of Chinese Parallel and Boston for different batches, and one city employs a combination of Chinese Parallel and allows for real-time adjustment to submitted preferences.

There are nine cities whose mechanisms seem to be Deferred Acceptance with a threshold score: Zhengzhou, Luoyang, Nanyang, Xinxiang, Kaifeng, Pingdingshan, Shangqiu, Xinyang, Changsha. Except for Changsha, which is in Hunan province, all of these cities are from Henan province.[13] These nine cities admit students

[12] Note that the discussion of mechanisms in this paper is preliminary and at most suggestive. More investigation is needed to ensure that these mechanisms on paper are implemented accordingly. Also, the mechanism for a given city is almost never clean-cut. That is, a city always employs a combination of various mechanisms. And the proportion of students admitted through each mechanism varies across cities. I only discuss the mechanism for "normal admissions" here. The 73 cities may not be representative of the population since the difficulty of retrieving mechanisms may correlate with other factors related to the mechanism itself.

[13] Both Hunan and Henan are recognized for their strong performance in education, particularly in terms of student outcomes in the Gaokao. They also have a history of pioneering education reforms. Changsha, for instance, adopted a CCAS for its high school education in 2007, making it rank among the earliest 5 percent of adopters among the 129 cities examined in this study.

based on an "admission score line," which differs from the threshold score and can vary among high schools and different types of admission (independent admission, normal admission, and distributive admission being the most common types).[14] This process resembles Deferred Acceptance because the admission score line is determined through a recursive process that involves continuous assessment of school capacity, student scores, and the parallel preferences of students. Consequently, if a student with a higher score fails to secure their top-choice school, they may replace a student with a lower score who was initially accepted by their top-choice school. This replacement can occur when the former student's second-choice school aligns with the latter student's top choice in the school's admission queue.

There are four cities that enable students to make real-time adjustments to their preference choices based on up-to-date information regarding their current ranking and school capacity. In this case, students are limited to selecting only one school at a time, resulting in a list length of 1. These cities are Nanning, Guilin, Hohhot and Baotou. Zunyi follows a unique approach by combining within-batch Serial Dictatorship with the option for adjustments, permitting up to three adjustments before the application deadline.

D Break-Tie Rules

The specific break-tie rules employed in these cities may vary in detail, but they typically involve evaluating a combination of subject scores and "comprehensive quality evaluation results." The latter metric is introduced to promote a shift toward "quality education" in China, as opposed to the traditional "exam-oriented education" approach. For instance, in Jieyang, when candidates have identical scores in the high school entrance examination (the Zhongkao), their ranking is determined based on the order of single subjects and scores in the following sequence: Chinese, Mathematics, English, Physics, Chemistry, Morality and the Rule of Law ("Politics"), History, Biology, Geography, and Physical Education. In Wurumqi, students with tied Zhongkao scores are sorted by, moving from one criterion to the next if the tie persists: comprehensive quality evaluation results, the number of A grades in each subject in the academic proficiency test for middle school graduates, physical examination grade, and the total score of the three core subjects: Chinese, Mathematics, and English.

E Priority Groups

Prioritized groups may have a higher initial ranking in the primary or middle school assignment process, or receive bonus scores that add to their Zhongkao scores. Priority group policies exhibit a high degree of uniformity across all cities, as they are subject to national regulations. These standard priority groups typically include children of martyrs, children of eligible active servicemen, children of public security heroes and police officers who died on

[14] Independent admission often applies to students with special talents in areas such as sports, music, dance, and the arts, constituting smaller than 10 percent of the admitted cohort. To improve educational equality, China has long been exploring the practice of distributing high school seats to middle schools, particularly those from disadvantaged backgrounds. In 2002, a ministerial document encouraged this policy. The goal is to eventually achieve 100 percent and make distributive admission the only means for admission. Most sampled cities have reached over 50 percent in 2022. However, there are variations in how distributed seats for a given middle school are allocated to students within that school. The effectiveness of this policy in improving educational equity in both the short and long term requires further study.

duty, children of national comprehensive fire rescue team members, and children of government-certified high-level talents. Occasionally, priority may also be extended to children of individuals who have made significant contributions to the local economy. Some cities have introduced new priority groups, such as children of medical personnel actively combating COVID-19 on the front lines, while many are reducing or eliminating bonus scores for children of a minority ethnicity (excluding Han ethnicity).

VI Current CCAS: Primary and Middle School

Among the 134 cities studied, 114 have established a city-level CCAS for mandatory education, while 13 cities have only district-level CCAS. The latter includes either oversized cities like Shenzhen, Guangzhou, and Beijing, or cities on the smaller end that have not yet unified their admission system. One major city, Nanjing, lacks a CCAS due to non-single assignments, as students can be assigned both to a public school and a private school. In Xining, parents still need to enroll their children at school in person. Unfortunately, no indicative information was found for Nantong, Chaozhou, Jieyang, Changshu, Huzhou, and Zhaoqing regarding their CCAS status.

A Participating Institutions

All 114 cities with city-level CCAS include both private and public schools in their centralized admission system, aligning with the policy mandating synchronized public and private school admission mentioned in Section IV.

B Mechanisms and List Lengths

The 2019 ministerial document, which mandated synchronized public and private school admission, also specified the main mechanisms for both public and private school admissions.

For public schools, student assignments are primarily based on their residential addresses. Since 2014, the Ministry of Education has prohibited the use of tests as a means of selection, as outlined in the "Implementation Opinions of the Ministry of Education on Further Improving the Enrollment of Primary School Graduates in Junior High Schools Nearby and Test-Free."[15] Parents generally need to log in to the official portal, provide their children's personal information, family residential address, and scanned documents like house ownership certificates and household registers. These documents are used to determine a child's initial eligibility and priority on the roster. Parents either indicate one preferred school or are not required to submit a preference.

For private schools, students are often asked to indicate one preferred school. If the number of students applying to a particular private school is equal to or smaller than the number of available seats, all applicants are admitted. If the number of applicants exceeds the available seats, the school admits students randomly until all seats are filled. In comparison, public schools are usually not subject to a rigid capacity constraint. Variation in implementation across cities primarily depends on how they coordinate the private school and public school

[15] Please see here.

systems. Some cities allow applications to both types of schools, while others require applicants to choose one. Some mandate that if a student applies to a private school, they must prove they have secured a seat in a public school as a fallback option. Additionally, some cities lower the priority of students in the public school applicant pool if they apply to private schools,[16] while others do not, or impose a time lag between the two processes.

C Priority Groups

Given the universal nature of compulsory education, priority groups function primarily as extensions of the eligibility criteria. The highest priority is typically assigned to children who satisfy the "three consistencies": the child's registered residence matches that of the parents (or grandparents or grandparents-in-law), the family resides together within the school district, and the registered residence corresponds to the property ownership certificate, which must be designated for residential use. Deviations from these "three consistencies" lowers a child's priority on the admission list.

Furthermore, the option to tie siblings together in the school assignment process so that they are assigned the same school has been introduced as a priority consideration, in response to China's transition away from the one-child policy.

VII Spatial Diffusion of CCAS Adoption

To study the spatial diffusion of CCAS adoption, I follow DellaVigna and Kim (2025) and Li, Zhu and Chen (2024) and estimate a hazard model of diffusion. I index cities by i and years by t. CCAS has two categories, high school CCAS, and mandatory-education CCAS with unified public–private admissions.[17] I estimate the model only for high school CCAS, because high school CCAS exhibits diffusion patterns as a predominantly bottom-up adoption in its early years, and mandatory-education CCAS (with synchronized public–private admissions) is centrally sponsored (top-down) around the 2019–2022 rollout. Let $Y_{it} \in \{0,1\}$ indicate whether city i first[18] adopts a high school CCAS in year t. For all cities labeled as i that have yet to adopt a high school CCAS by year t, we employ a logit specification to model the discrete-choice decision pertaining to CCAS adoption:

$$\log\left(\frac{\Pr(Y_{it}=1)}{1-\Pr(Y_{it}=1)}\right) = \alpha\Lambda_{it} + f\big(X_{i0}\big) + D_{rt} + \varepsilon_{it}, \tag{1}$$

where Λ_{it} measures exposure to prior CCAS adopters through spatial and economic proximity. $f(X_{i0})$ is a *flexible* function of baseline city covariates, and r indexes macro-region or province.[19] D_{rt} are region or province by year fixed effects.

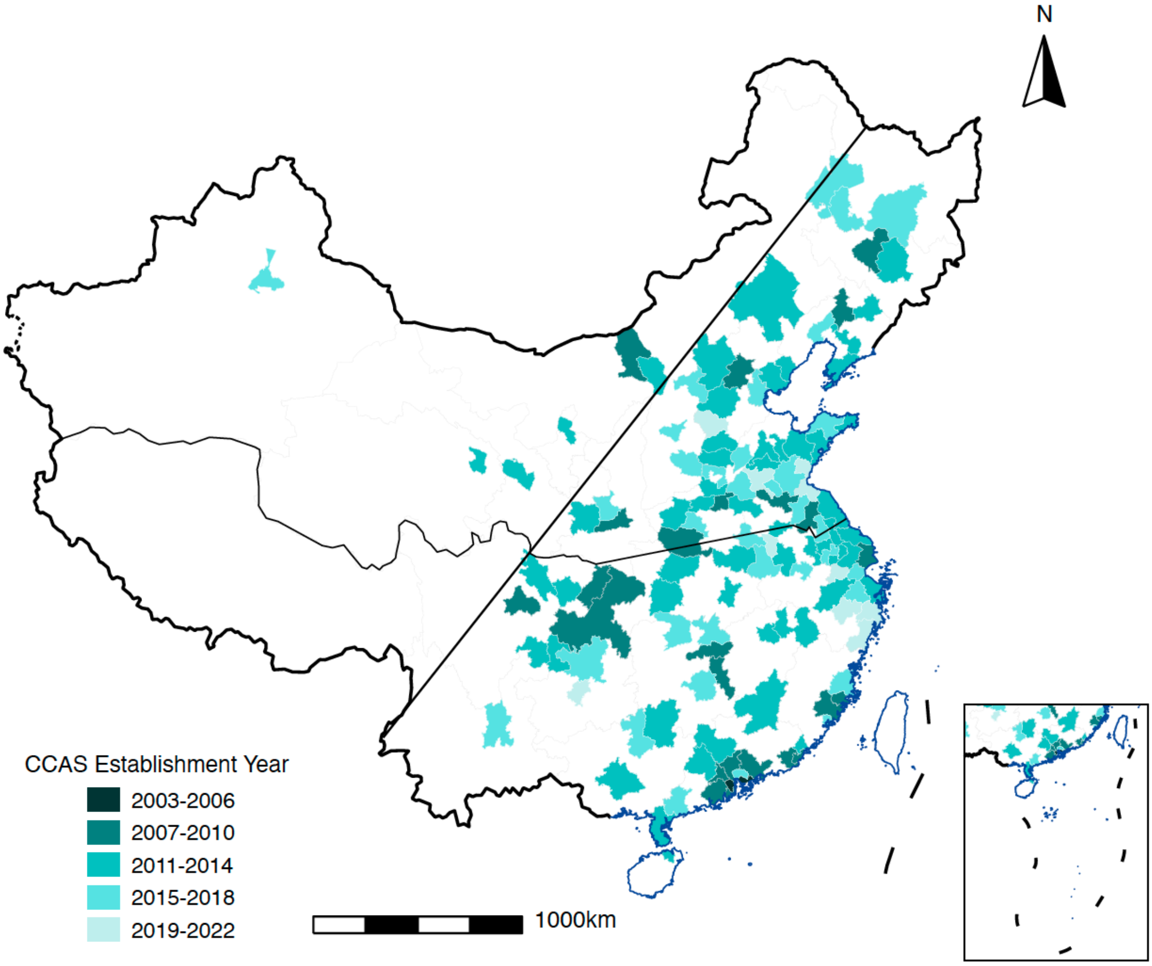
[16] These individuals may fail to be admitted in the best public schools, but will be guaranteed a seat at a school due to the nature of mandatory education.

[17] I may also consider mechanism-level variants (e.g., Chinese Parallel, Boston, deferred acceptance) as distinct q in extensions.

[18] Because we are interested in diffusion of adoption instead of CCAS prevalence (stock).

[19] Regions consist of the east, central, and west regions.

Figure 8: The Establishment Year of High School CCAS



Notes: This map shows the establishment year of high school CCAS among the surveyed cities. The diagonal line is the Heihe-Tengchong line. The lower right box contains the South China Sea islands.

I construct the measure that capture city i's exposure to CCAS in year t as follows:

$$\Lambda_{it} = \sum_{j \neq i} \omega_{ij} \mathbf{1}\{j \in \Omega_{t-1}\}, \qquad \omega_{ij} = \frac{\left(\text{Dist}_{ij}\right)^{-1} \text{Pop}_{j0}}{\sum_{j' \neq i} \left(\text{Dist}_{ij'}\right)^{-1} \text{Pop}_{j'0}}. \tag{2}$$

where Ω_{t-1} denotes the set of cities that had adopted CCAS by year $t-1$. I weight each early adopter in the set Ω_{t-1} by the product of the inverse of bilateral distance $\left(\text{Dist}_{ij}\right)^{-1}$ and its baseline population Pop_{j0}. A potential adopter has a greater exposure to CCAS category q when more counties have adopted it, especially when these early adopters are larger in size and located in close proximity. Hence, a larger Λ_{it} likely indicates that more information regarding q has spread from other regions to city i, providing a better opportunity for city i to observe the returns and assess the costs of adopting the reform.

Additionally, in Equation (1), the vector X_{i0} contains time-invariant baseline city characteristics, including log population, GRP per capita, sectoral employment composition, and average education levels for males and females. D_{rt} denotes region–year or province–year fixed effects, absorbing broad administrative campaigns, regional growth shocks, and common institutional reforms. Robust standard errors are clustered at the province level to allow for arbitrary serial correlation and cross-city covariance within provinces.

To flexibly capture how baseline city characteristics influence adoption hazards, we include a second-order polynomial basis expansion of X_{i0}, allowing for both nonlinearities and pairwise interactions:

$$f(X_{i0}) = \sum_k \beta_k x_{i0}^k + \sum_k \gamma_k \left(x_{i0}^k\right)^2 + \sum_{k<\ell} \delta_{k\ell} x_{i0}^k x_{i0}^\ell.$$

In practice, each continuous baseline covariate is first standardized (mean zero, unit variance), and the model includes all linear terms (log population, GRP per capita, share of employment in agriculture sector, share of employment in industrial sector, female and male average years of education), their squares, and all pairwise interaction terms.

This specification corresponds to a second-order polynomial sieve approximation to $f(\cdot)$. It replaces the similarity index in Li, Zhu and Chen (2024) with a flexible representation of baseline adoption propensity.

Table 1: Spatial Diffusion of High School CCAS Adoption: Hazard Model Estimates

	Dependent variable:			
	CCAS Adoption (Y_{it})			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Exposure to CCAS (Λ_{it})	2.313	2.125	2.422	−8.439
	(1.880)	(2.288)	(2.004)	(5.579)
Log population	0.291*	0.305*	0.239	0.562
	(0.158)	(0.165)	(0.214)	(0.369)
GRP per capita	0.227	0.033	0.083	−0.526
	(0.138)	(0.182)	(0.248)	(0.992)
Share employment in agricultural sector	0.001	0.189	0.154	−0.565
	(0.106)	(0.193)	(0.256)	(0.734)
Share employment in industrial sector	−0.148	−0.075	0.022	0.274
	(0.110)	(0.111)	(0.152)	(0.316)
Female average education	−0.038	0.079	0.220	0.852
	(0.263)	(0.254)	(0.274)	(1.267)
Male average education	0.491*	0.417*	0.290	0.489
	(0.285)	(0.226)	(0.259)	(1.269)
Region × Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Province × Year FE	No	No	No	Yes
Quadratic terms	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Interaction terms	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,403	1,403	1,403	1,403

Notes: Standard errors (clustered at the province level) are in parentheses. All continuous baseline covariates are standardized prior to estimation. Sample: City-year observations for cities that have not yet adopted high school CCAS by year t. Exposure Λ_{it} weights prior adopters by inverse distance and baseline population. Models (1)–(3) include region×year fixed effects; Model (4) includes province×year FE.
$^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$

Table 1 reports estimates of the hazard model in Equation (1). Across all specifications, the coefficient on the exposure measure Λ_{it} is statistically insignificant. The data therefore do not support the hypothesis that cities with greater exposure to prior adopters are more likely to adopt high school CCAS.

Among the baseline covariates, standardized log population is positively correlated with high school CCAS adoption, particularly in the simpler specifications. This is consistent with the idea that larger cities have greater administrative capacity, market competition among schools, and stronger incentives to reform admission mechanisms. Male average education demonstrates a positive and statistically significant effect in the simpler model specifications, while female average education remains insignificant throughout. This discrepancy warrants further investigation and may reflect underlying differences in political influence or perceptions about the returns to education reform across genders. This suggests the importance of gender dynamics in educational policy diffusion and implementation.

These findings collectively paint a nuanced picture of CCAS diffusion in China. The lack of significant spatial diffusion effects, combined with the importance of city size and potentially male education levels, suggests that CCAS adoption may be driven more by local capacity and human capital considerations than by geographical proximity to prior adopters. Moreover, comparing models (1)-(3) with (4) hints at the importance of provincial-level dynamics, which appear to play a substantial role in shaping the landscape of CCAS adoption.

However, all results, including the insignificance of the diffusion effect, should be interpreted with the caveats that 134 is a very small sample size and that the examined cities are selected based on their large population. As can be seen from Figure 8, the selected cities are somewhat geographically sparse. As we extend this analysis to CCAS adoption worldwide, we may find different and more definitive results.

Isolating a causal effect of exposure on adoption is intrinsically difficult in this setting. Changes in Λ_{it} can coincide with spatially correlated unobservables that also raise adoption propensity, making "learning" observationally similar to common shocks. This is essentially a variant of the "reflection" problem (Manski, 1993): it is hard to distinguish (i) endogenous peer effects and learning, (ii) exogenous contextual effects (features of the reference group—e.g., shared provincial guidance or constraints, implementation of provincial digital admission systems, political pressure from provincial leaders), and (iii) correlated effects (cities face similar unobservable determinants of CCAS adoption). In linear (and many nonlinear) models using group means/lags, these forces are not separately identified from observational data without extra structure or instruments; the endogenous coefficient is algebraically "absorbed" into composites of contextual and correlated effects. The broader policy-diffusion literature also documents how shared institutions and partisan or administrative linkages can mimic contagion (Berry and Berry, 1990; Shipan and Volden, 2008). Identification only improves if we already know reference-group composition and there is informative variation linking those groups to direct city covariates, otherwise the reduced-form coefficients should be read as associations, not causal effects of learning.

Future research should delve deeper into the specific provincial policies and institutional factors that drive CCAS adoption, as well as explore why traditional spatial diffusion effects appear weak in this particular educational reform context. Such investigations could yield valuable insights for understanding and facilitating the spread of similar educational reforms across diverse regional landscape in China and beyond.

VIII Conclusion

This paper provides the first systematic documentation of the emergence and design of centralized student choice and assignment systems (CCAS) in Chinese basic education. Using original data collection from municipal policy documents, local government releases, and public reporting, I assemble a cross-sectional dataset on CCAS presence and mechanism design for 134 large Chinese cities, alongside a panel of city characteristics from 2003 to 2022. I show that CCAS for high school admission expanded gradually between 2003 and 2022, reflecting decentralized experimentation and local initiative, while CCAS for mandatory education expanded rapidly after 2019 following a national mandate to unify public and private admissions. This distinction underscores the coexistence of bottom-up policymaking and top-down administrative coordination in China's education governance.

The data also reveal substantial cross-city heterogeneity in CCAS design. At the high school level, most cities run unified admissions for both public and private schools, but list lengths, tie-breaking rules, and priority categories vary. Mechanism choice is concentrated but not uniform: more than half of documented cities use the Chinese Parallel mechanism, while Boston, deferred acceptance (DA), and hybrid mechanisms also appear. At the mandatory-education level, public and private admissions are coordinated differently across cities, with many relying on single-choice submissions and random assignment to private schools when oversubscribed. The increasing use of sibling-based priority signals evolving family-policy considerations in the post–one-child-policy era.

To study the diffusion of high school CCAS, I estimate a discrete-time hazard model relating adoption timing to exposure to prior adopters and to flexible functions of baseline city characteristics. Across specifications, the coefficient on the exposure measure is small and statistically insignificant, suggesting limited evidence of diffusion through spatial or informational contagion. Instead, adoption correlates more consistently with underlying city fundamentals such as population size and (in simpler models) male educational attainment. These relationships, however, should be interpreted descriptively rather than causally: distinguishing true learning from shared provincial guidance or spatially correlated administrative capacity is inherently difficult. As highlighted by Manski (1993), endogenous peer effects, contextual effects, and correlated effects are observationally intertwined in settings where units share governance, information channels, and institutional history. The hazard estimates therefore map patterns in adoption, not causal channels.

The contribution of this paper is descriptive and foundational. I map the prevalence and design of CCAS across major Chinese cities, characterize the substantial cross-city heterogeneity in mechanisms and rules, and explore the distinct diffusion patterns governing high school and compulsory-education centralization. These findings supply the empirical groundwork needed for future evaluations of CCAS impacts on equity, efficiency, and human capital development, informing the design of education policies and complementary institutional structures.

Future research can build on my work in three directions. First, expanding the dataset to include smaller cities and county-level systems would allow a fuller analysis of diffusion and heterogeneity in governance capacity. Second, linking admissions policies to student-level administrative records would make it possible to evaluate the distributional effects of CCAS on access to high-quality schools. Third, expanding the sample from Chinese cities to cities around the world, as is one aim of the worldwide CCAS project, would allow for better causal identification of both the driving factors and the effects of CCAS. Such evidence would be valuable not only for understanding China's education reforms, but also for informing CCAS implementation in other countries navigating increasing demand for transparent and equitable school assignment systems.

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A Appendix

A.1 Tables and Figures

Table A1: Sampled Cities, Population, and CCAS Establishment Years

City Name (ENG)	Population in 2020	Primary and Middle School CCAS Establishment Year	High School CCAS Establishment Year
Shanghai	21,909,814	2015	2007
Beijing	18,960,744	District-level	2007
Shenzhen	17,444,609	District-level	2003
Guangzhou	16,096,724	District-level	2008
Chengdu	13,568,357	2022	2009
Tianjin	11,052,404	2018	2016
Wuhan	10,494,879	2023	2012
Dongguan	9,644,871	2020	2015
Chongqing	9,580,819	2019	2010
Xi'an	9,392,938	2019	2010
Hangzhou	9,236,032	2019	2011
Foshan	9,042,509	District-level	2008
Nanjing	7,519,814	No CCAS	2011
Shenyang	7,026,358	2017	2010
Zhengzhou	6,461,013	2020	2011
Qingdao	6,165,279	2021	2012
Suzhou	5,892,892	2020	2011
Jinan	5,648,162	2021	2012
Changsha	5,630,256	2020	2007
Kunming	5,273,144	2019	2015
Harbin	5,242,897	2020	2015
Shijiazhuang	5,090,440	2021	2022
Hefei	5,055,978	2021	2013
Dalian	4,913,879	2020	2014
Xiamen	4,617,251	2022	2016
Nanning	4,582,703	2019	2013
Changchun	4,557,356	2010	2010
Taiyuan	4,303,673	2020	2015

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Table A1 – continued from previous page

City Name (ENG)	Population in 2020	Primary and Middle School CCAS Establishment Year	High School CCAS Establishment Year
Guiyang	4,021,275	2019	2021
Wuxi	3,956,985	2022	2012
Urumqi	3,864,136	2020	2015
Zhongshan	3,841,873	2020	2005
Shantou	3,838,900	2020	2010
Ningbo	3,731,203	2020	2013
Fuzhou	3,723,454	2020	2017
Nanchang	3,518,975	2022	2011
Changzhou	3,187,315	2023	2016
Lanzhou	3,012,577	District-level	2012
Nantong	2,987,600	NA	2012
Huizhou	2,900,113	District-level	2008
Xuzhou	2,845,552	2020	2010
Zibo	2,750,312	2021	2013
Linyi	2,743,843	2021	2015
Wenzhou	2,582,017	2019	2020
Tangshan	2,549,968	District-level	2014
Hohhot	2,373,399	2015	2011
Haikou	2,349,239	2020	2011
Shaoxing	2,333,080	2020	2018
Yantai	2,311,885	2021	2015
Luoyang	2,230,661	2021	2013
Zhuhai	2,207,090	2020	2010
Liuzhou	2,204,841	2021	2015
Baotou	2,104,114	2023	2009
Handan	2,095,134	2020	2011
Yangzhou	2,067,254	2020	2016
Weifang	1,998,405	2019	2014
Baoding	1,940,384	District-level	2013
Datong	1,809,505	2020	2015
Huai'an	1,804,611	2020	2010

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Table A1 – continued from previous page

City Name (ENG)	Population in 2020	Primary and Middle School CCAS Establishment Year	High School CCAS Establishment Year
Jiangmen	1,795,459	2023	2010
Ganzhou	1,778,132	2022	2012
lining	1,700,054	2021	2022
Xiangyang	1,686,403	2020	2011
Xining	1,677,177	2017	2014
Zunyi	1,675,245	District-level	2015
Yinchuan	1,662,968	2020	2012
Kunshan	1,652,159	2019	2016
Daqing	1,604,027	2020	2015
Wuhu	1,598,165	2020	2016
Mianyang	1,549,499	2022	2011
Putian	1,539,389	2020	2010
Qinhuangdao	1,520,199	2022	2013
Zhuzhou	1,510,148	2020	2010
Jilin	1,509,292	2016	2013
Taizhou	1,485,502	2020	$\leq$ 2022
Yiwu	1,481,384	2020	2022
Xingtai	1,480,754	2020	2011
Anshan	1,480,332	2023	2014
Quanzhou	1,469,157	2020	2007
Cixi	1,457,510	2020	$\leq$ 2022
Tai'an	1,416,591	2021	2013
Jinjiang	1,416,151	2020	2009
Nanyang	1,407,616	2020	2010
Zhanjiang	1,400,709	2020	2013
Guilin	1,361,244	2021	2014
Yancheng	1,353,475	2020	2014
Zaozhuang	1,349,883	2021	2017
Taizhou	1,348,327	2020	2011
Shangrao	1,342,220	2022	2012
Weihai	1,339,645	District-level	2013

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Table A1 – continued from previous page

City Name (ENG)	Population in 2020	Primary and Middle School CCAS Establishment Year	High School CCAS Establishment Year
Zhangjiakou	1,339,384	2022	2014
Jiangyin	1,331,352	2020	$\leq$ 2022
Maoming	1,307,802	2020	2018
Heze	1,293,767	2021	2017
Yichang	1,284,305	2018	2012
Xinxiang	1,271,350	2020	2012
Huainan	1,255,619	2019	2019
Nanchong	1,254,455	2022	2014
Chaozhou	1,254,007	NA	2014
Jieyang	1,242,906	NA	2009
Changshu	1,230,599	NA	$\leq$ 2021
Fushun	1,228,890	2020	2014
Qingyuan	1,197,581	District-level	2012
Kaifeng	1,193,802	2020	2010
Xianyang	1,192,776	2020	2015
Fuyang	1,191,810	2019	2017
Jiaxing	1,188,321	2019	2016
Anyang	1,187,772	2022	2016
Hengyang	1,185,130	2020	2015
Rizhao	1,147,175	2020	2021
Dazhou	1,135,817	2022	2009
Luzhou	1,128,479	2022	2012
Yueyang	1,125,448	2020	2015
Zhenjiang	1,123,813	2021	2013
Baoji	1,107,702	2020	2011
Yibin	1,100,737	2022	2012
Changde	1,100,719	2020	2015
Chifeng	1,093,068	2023	2014
Huzhou	1,083,953	NA	2019
Suqian	1,081,559	2018	2016
Bengbu	1,077,704	2019	2014

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Table A1 – continued from previous page

City Name (ENG)	Population in 2020	Primary and Middle School CCAS Establishment Year	High School CCAS Establishment Year
Lianyungang	1,071,019	2020	2019
Lu'an	1,069,940	2019	2018
Zhangjiagang	1,055,893	2020	$\leq$ 2022
Changzhi	1,047,461	District-level	2015
Pingdingshan	1,045,966	2020	2016
Jinhua	1,040,948	2020	2021
Zhaoqing	1,035,810	NA	2013
Shangqiu	1,031,123	2020	2014
Qiqihar	1,029,522	District-level	2016
Jinzhou	1,021,478	2020	2017
Liaocheng	1,020,430	2021	2015
Xinyang	1,014,843	2020	2013
Yuyao	1,013,866	2020	2017

Notes: This table summarizes the names of the sampled cities, their population in 2020, and the years in which they established a CCAS in high school and compulsory education admission.

A.2 Standard Procedures of Basic Education Enrollment

High School

1. Eligibility

   Eligibility for high school application is linked to the eligibility criteria for signing up for the Zhongkao. To qualify, a student must "love their motherland, abide by the law, and have good conduct," have completed middle school, and maintain good physical health. There may be slight variations in the specific registered residence requirements across cities. Students who are already enrolled in high school education or its equivalent are not eligible to apply.

2. Admission Region

   Public high schools are permitted to admit students exclusively from their designated school district, as mandated by the government. However, exceptions may arise in cases of student enrollment imbalances in specific schools, allowing government intervention to redistribute students across affiliated areas. Private high schools and vocational schools, on the other hand, may have the flexibility to admit students from different parts of the city. That is, their designated "affiliated area" may be the entire city as opposed to a sub-city district.

3. Application Procedures

   (a) Students interested in attending high school must submit their preference list through the BoE's designated website. The timing of this submission varies among cities. Of the 39 cities for which I documented this variable, 26 require students to submit their preferences after receiving their Zhongkao scores, and 13 allow submissions either before the Zhongkao examination, or after Zhongkao but before the score announcement.

       Priority groups are allocated bonus scores that augment a student's Zhongkao score, resulting in a "modified score." This modified score serves as the primary basis for a student's final ranking in the applicant pool.

   (b) The Bureau of Education assigns each student to one high school based on a specific mechanism, detailed in Section V, subsection C.

   (c) The student ultimately decides whether to accept the assignment and attend the designated high school.

Primary and Middle School

1. Eligibility

   (a) The eligibility criteria for primary and middle (junior high) schools in a given city encompass several categories of children and adolescents, including:

      i. Children and adolescents with household registration in the city;[20]

      ii. Eligible accompanying children of the migrant population;

      iii. Children and adolescents eligible otherwise as stipulated by national, provincial, and municipal policies:

         A. Children and adolescents whose parents work in China's overseas agencies or are dispatched abroad for long-term business, or who work in the field geological survey department, so that the child or adolescent in the place their household registration lacks a caretaker, and they need to be taken care of by relatives or fostered in this city;

         B. Children of active servicemen of the city's garrison;

         C. Children and adolescents whose immediate family members or other legal guardians are registered in this city, but who are: children of martyrs, children of soldiers who died on duty, children of soldiers with disabilities of level 1 to 4, children of soldiers who have won second-class merit in peacetime or third-class merit in wartime or above; children of active-duty soldiers stationed in state-recognized difficult and remote areas and the Tibet Autonomous Region, islands of the third category or above as designated by the People's Liberation Army's

[20] This category accounts for the majority of cases, and further details may specify how applicants are ranked or initially prioritized in the school assignment system. Please see Section VI subsection C.

headquarter, or of active-duty soldiers who work in high-risk and high-danger positions such as aviation, submarines, aerospace, and nuclear-related positions;

D. Children and adolescents of high-level talents or innovative and entrepreneurial talents in accordance with specific local policies and verified by local government departments;

E. Children and adolescents who are registered in Hong Kong, Macao, Taiwan, or are of foreign nationalities residing in this city.

iv. The above-mentioned children and adolescents must also meet the following requirements:

- Primary school (including the primary school sector of nine-year schools, similar below): Children who were born between September 1, (current year - 7) to August 31, (current year - 6) and aged 6 or above, or children who have been approved by the urban or county (city) education administrative department to postpone their compulsory education.
- Middle school: Fresh primary school graduates.

2. Admission Region

Public primary schools primarily admit students based on school districts. They may also admit students directly from affiliated primary schools.

Private schools can only admit students within their "approved area." The private schools approved by the district and county education administrative departments can only admit students within that district, and the private schools that have leftover seats from the first round of admission can usually participate in a supplementary round of admission. Private schools approved by the city municipal education bureau should first enroll students within the district where the school is located. Those who have leftover seats from the enrollment within the district can apply for a supplementary round of admission that expands the admission region to the entire city with the approval of the city municipal education bureau.

3. Application Procedures

(a) Parents or students create an account and log in on the designated website.

(b) They must submit eligibility documents (such as registered address and house property ownership certificate) and personal information (including name, ID, age, and gender).

(c) Applicants may be required to submit a preference, with rules varying across cities. In some cases, this step may be optional. For example, when this city requires no preference indication for public primary schools, or when a given primary school's graduating cohort is automatically admitted to a middle school.

(d) Supplementary admission rounds may occur for students who have not yet been assigned to a school after the initial rounds of admission.

(e) After a specified date, parents or students can check their school assignment results on the website, and there may be an option to receive notification of the result through a text message.